

ON TECHNIQUE

Twelve-tone music

In the early 1920s, Schoenberg invented a wholly original method of composition to replace traditional scales and chords. Music was to be composed using “tone rows” made up of all 12 notes of the chromatic scale, with no note being repeated. These rows could be inverted, reversed, transposed, or otherwise transformed. Schoenberg presented this system as a revolutionary breakthrough, comparable to the physicist Albert Einstein’s theory of relativity. Avant-garde composers after World War II erected the 12-tone system into the dogma of “serialism,” but Schoenberg himself said that there was “still plenty of good music to be written in C major.”